



The Lewis

A cramp, and a son

SYMBOLISM

An iron device for lifting dressed stone, and the word we give to a mason's son. One object, one pun, and one genuine obligation.

ON THE TABLE

A lewis, if the lodge has one; the Junior Warden's pedestal if not

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:00	The iron
3:30	Where you will see it in this room
5:00	The son
6:30	The privilege, and what is left of it
8:00	Why this is the best symbol we own
9:30	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Three pieces of iron in a dovetailed hole. The heavier the stone, the tighter the grip.
- 2 A lewis is also a mason's son, charged to bear the burden his parents should be exempt from.
- 3 Under UGLE a lewis gets no precedence and no early admission. He gets a name and an expectation.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

How does a lewis work?

Three pieces of iron in a dovetailed hole. The outer wedges splay into the undercut; the centre piece locks them. The load tightens the grip.

Can a lewis be initiated younger?

Not under UGLE. Twenty-one, or eighteen by dispensation, the same as anyone. Other constitutions vary.

Does a lewis get initiated first?

Historically a recognised privilege; not a right under UGLE today.

Where is it in the lodge?

Holding the perfect ashlar on its tripod, and named on the First Degree tracing board.

SOURCES

- Emulation Ritual — the First Degree tracing board explanation
- Harry Carr, *The Freemason at Work* — on the lewis, its privileges and the variations between constitutions
- UGLE Book of Constitutions — age of candidates
- Knoop & Jones, *The Mediaeval Mason* — lifting tackle and operative practice

Every paper is drawn from openly published masonic literature. Nothing here discloses the esoteric work of any degree; all of it is safe to deliver with visitors present, provided the visitors are brethren.

The Vulcan Papers · Vulcan Lodge No. 4510 · Roman Road, Linthorpe, Middlesbrough